WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-08-31 to 2026-09-06

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SUMMARY

COMAP Journal Bot found a week in which political influence, AI-mediated inference, and the public life of platforms converge. The most consequential new work maps how Russian-aligned narrative laundering shapes issue agendas, offers causal inference with text and images through generative models, benchmarks LLM-based digital twins against people, and tests a multimodal field campaign designed to restore election trust.

Across the wider set, papers examine online congressional representation, political polarization, privacy and biometric governance, human-AI intimacy, topic-model robustness, voter accountability, and the cross-platform politicization of social-justice discourse. Several secondary selections extend the computational and governance lens to road-infrastructure inequality, biodiversity supply chains, and policy design in smallholder agriculture.

- New This Week: 25 papers spanning authoritarian information operations, AI-enabled methods, political communication, public opinion, digital privacy, and governance.
- Catch-Up: 18 papers, preserving the prior week's reviewed set and adding a newly indexed Journal of Communication study of neighborhood chat groups.
- Late Additions: none in this collection cycle.
- Timing note: This digest was prepared on Saturday, 2026-09-05, before the nominal window closed on Sunday, 2026-09-06; later publications may be recovered in a subsequent catch-up or late-additions section.

HIGHLIGHTS

State-sponsored agenda setting: Measuring the impact of narrative laundering

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-09-04

Why it matters · Tracks a Russian-aligned influence campaign across state media, fabricated sites, and paid influencers, shifting attention from direct persuasion to the agenda-setting effects of laundered narratives.

Open article →

Leveraging generative AI for causal inference with unstructured data

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-09-03

Why it matters · Introduces an open-source framework for causal inference with text and images, demonstrated on Chinese censorship, political imagery, and rhetorical persuasion.

Open article →

Digital twins are funhouse mirrors: Five systematic distortions

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-09-04

Why it matters · Benchmarks LLM-based digital twins across 19 preregistered studies and documents individuation, stereotyping, representation, ideological, and hyper-rationality failures.

Open article →

Can a public information campaign increase trust in American elections?

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-09-04

Why it matters · Tests a professionally produced multimodal campaign in the field during the 2024 election, finding much smaller trust effects than prior survey experiments suggested.

Open article →

Measuring Partisanship and Representation in Online Congressional Communications

AMERICAN POLITICAL SCIENCE REVIEW · 2026-09-01

Why it matters · Brings measurement of representation into legislators' online communication, directly connecting digital trace data to core questions of partisanship and democratic responsiveness.

Open article →

From #StayWoke to "Culture Wars": How Social Justice Discourse is Separately and Synergistically Politicized on Twitter and YouTube

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-08-31

Why it matters · Examines how social-justice language is politicized across two distinct platform environments, making it especially useful for cross-platform political communication research.

Open article →

Saturation of moral language predicts lower content engagement on social media

NATURE HUMAN BEHAVIOUR · 2026-09-02

Why it matters · Links moral-language density to audience response at platform scale, offering a sharp result for work on political expression, attention, and message design.

Open article →

Context, script, cue: understanding human-AI intimate relationships

JOURNAL OF COMPUTER-MEDIATED COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-01

Why it matters · Develops a communication-centered account of intimate relationships with AI, a timely framework for studying how people interpret and respond to synthetic social actors.

Open article →

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- Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences
- Science Advances

Previous Week Catch-Up

- American Journal of Political Science
- Communication Research
- Journal of Communication
- Nature
- Nature Communications
- Nature Human Behaviour
- Political Communication
- Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences
- Science
- Science Advances

COLLECTION SNAPSHOT

TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES
329	159	170
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES	**CURATED DIGEST BELOW**	**NOTE**
0	25 new, 18 catch-up, 0 late additions	The counts above reflect the complete collected set before manual relevance filtering, while the attached PDF and full HTML reflect the curated digest.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

American Journal of Political Science

The territorial rights of wild animals: Justification

2026-08-31 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70087

Pablo P. Castello

Sturm College of Law, University of Denver Denver Colorado USA

Abstract. Abstract Territorial rights (TR) have become foundational in normative political theory, addressing pressing questions about boundary drawing, governance, and resource use. Influential TR theorists Cara Nine and Margaret Moore justify humans' TR based on the functional, social, and identityanchored normative significance of nonsubstitutable places. However, these arguments treat animals as resources, excluding them from normative consideration and political standing. This article analyzes Nine and Moore's arguments to assess whether their justificatory logic applies to wild animals. Using mule deers as a case study, I test whether they have sufficiently weighty interests in occupancy, residency, resource use, and control to ground duties on humans and whether TR theories should continue to treat animals as mere natural resources.

Read article →

American Political Science Review

Are Voters Myopic or Looking for Improvement?

2026-09-01 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101853

MARKUS PRIOR; TALBOT M. ANDREWS

Cornell University; Princeton University

Abstract. Abstract Timing of valence outcomes plays an important role in key theories of electoral choice, and different models place different emphases on past and future outcomes. Whereas sanctioning models consider only retrospective evaluations as an accountability mechanism, selection models hold that voters use past and proposed future conditions to infer the incumbent's ability to deliver benefits. Drawing on four surveys run on six different samples, we demonstrate that voters prefer improving conditions in both retrospection and prospection. In retrospection, this pattern is difficult to distinguish from overweighting of temporally proximate conditions, which gave rise to the notion of "the myopic voter." Distinguishing the two processes, we find that people do not ignore early datapoints and reward improving conditions (in both retrospection and prospection). This preference for improvement does not simply reflect an uncritical heuristic for upward trends. People are not universally myopic and many genuinely value improving aggregate conditions retrospectively and prospectively.

Read article →

Measuring Partisanship and Representation in Online Congressional Communications

2026-09-01 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101841

MICHAEL KISTNER; MICHAEL HESELTINE; ROBERT ALVAREZ; MAYA FITCH; LUCAS LOTHAMER; ELIZABETH SIMAS

Sam Houston State University; Texas A&M University; University of Houston; University of Oxford; University of Texas at Tyler

Abstract. Social media and the internet have created new ways for representatives to communicate. How have members of Congress responded to these opportunities? We introduce a multi-platform dataset of congressional communications

extending back to the onset of the social media era. Using computational language processing, we classify approximately 4.7 million tweets, 2.4 million Facebook posts, and 184,000 email newsletters authored by members of Congress between 2009 and 2022 based on intended purpose, and scale the partisanship of each message along a continuous left-right dimension. After validation, we demonstrate how our data can be used to study partisanship and representation in the contemporary Congress. Importantly, our data show congressional rhetoric has become more partisan and negative as social media usage has increased. We identify one potential mechanism contributing to this trend: partisanship and negativity receive inflated levels of positive engagement on social media relative to other forms of messaging like credit claiming or constituency service.

Read article →

Communication Methods and Measures

Beyond beyond standardization: studying robustness of empirical claims based on topic modeling through multiverse analysis

2026-08-31 · DOI 10.1080/19312458.2026.2714769

Paul Balluff; Christina Viehmann; Maximilian Linde; Yannik Peters; Jun Sun; Chung-Hong Chan

GESIS - Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences

Abstract. While topic modeling is widely used, some scholars have already announced that the application of topic modeling in social science research is impossible to standardize. Meanwhile, researchers have to make numerous methodological decisions, yet base their empirical claims on just one topic model. This raises the question of robustness about those claims. In this study, we apply the framework of preregistered multiverse analysis to evaluate the robustness of previous empirical claims from six studies that were based on topic modeling. Based on the Open Science materials of these six studies, we slightly modify the original topic modeling procedures, such as preprocessing, number of topic clusters, and topic modeling algorithm, to other defensible choices and determine whether the empirical claims remain consistent. Even though we observe that certain empirical claims are more robust, most claims are distorted considerably by changes to the modeling options. The contributions of this study are twofold. First, we confirm that empirical claims based on just one topic model might not be robust against numerous researcher degrees of freedom. Second, we advocate a wider adoption of preregistered multiverse analysis in social science research for checking the robustness of empirical findings.

Read article →

Communication Research

Investigating Conditional Macro-Level Media Effects Over a Long-Term: How Crisis Periods Moderate the Effects of Suicide Coverage on Suicide Rate Change (1861-2007)

2026-09-03 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261480405

Christina Viehmann; Stefan Gei; Manina Biermayer; Oliver Quiring; Florian Arendt

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Abstract. How does media shape society over decades, and does its effect vary depending on the societal atmosphere or zeitgeist ? While theoretically important, there is a lack of systematic empirical evidence on conditional long-term macro-level media effects. We propose a broader framework to study such effects and demonstrate its applicability for the "Werther effect" in the UK. More specifically, we investigate whether media coverage of suicides in a newspaper of record is linked to suicide rates and whether this link changes during societal crises. For this, we combine suicide data with a large-scale automated content analysis of crisis and suicide reporting in The Times over a century (1861-2007). Our analysis shows that increased suicide reporting is associated with higher suicide rates, but only during crisis periods. The results are consistent

with a conditional Werther effect and may offer one piece of the larger puzzle of long-term macro-level media influences on society.

Read article →

Experimental Research on Stereotype Expression in Freely Generated Language: A Systematic Literature Review

2026-09-01 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261478981

Kim T. Beenen; Camiel J. Beukeboom; Christian Burgers; Pia Sommerauer

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Abstract. Social stereotypes spread through biased language. Experiments in which participants freely generate language allow researchers to causally test how stereotypes affect language use and capture multiple linguistic variables simultaneously, offering high ecological validity. Despite this potential, it remains unclear how and to which extent this paradigm has been used to study linguistic biases. To address this gap, we conducted a systematic literature review (k = 106 experiments) and found that most freely generated language experiments examined only one linguistic variable, leaving the interplay between linguistic variables largely underexplored. To advance our understanding of stereotype expression in everyday language, we recommend experiments to measure multiple linguistic variables simultaneously and in relation to each other. This knowledge is needed to address harmful stereotype communication in the real world through automated detection tools, communication interventions, and the fine-tuning of Large Language Models.

Read article →

Sex, Romance, or Recreation? An Experiment Testing the Effects of Cannabis Brand-generated Social Media Ads on College Students' Expectancies and Intentions to Use Cannabis Prior to Sex

2026-08-31 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261480401

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Abstract. Sexual and romantic scripts are used to market cannabis products, now legal for adult-use in several U.S. states. We conducted an online experiment (N = 747) examining the impact of viewing brand-generated social media posts promoting cannabis that included sexual, romantic, and non-sexual non-romantic recreational scripts among college students in Washington state. Increased perceptions that ads suggested cannabis enhances sex were associated with higher sex-related cannabis expectancies. Among men, wishful identification was associated with lower sexual risk expectancies among those who viewed sexual scripts and a greater likelihood of intending to use cannabis before sex among those who viewed sexual or romantic scripts. Among women, perceiving that ads suggested cannabis enhances sex was associated with a greater likelihood of intending to use cannabis before sex, whereas perceiving that ads suggested cannabis impacts sexual consent was associated with a lower likelihood of intending to use cannabis before sex. Additionally, wishful identification among women was associated with a greater likelihood of intending to use cannabis before sex. Findings highlight associations between perceptions of brand-generated social media posts, expectancies, and intentions to use cannabis before sex among college students and identify mechanisms through which effects may occur.

Read article →

Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication

A comparative test of the protection motivation theory: active and passive privacy protection in Brazil, Germany, the United States, and Vietnam

2026-09-01 · DOI 10.1093/JCMC/ZMAG019

Yannic Meier; Laurent H Wang; Nicole C Kramer; Miriam J Metzger

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Abstract. Abstract Online companies surveil users around the world for commercial purposes. We advance protection motivation theory (PMT), by categorizing user responses to surveillance as either active or passive (i.e., self-inhibition) privacy protection behavior, integrating privacy literacy overconfidence, and exploring privacy resignation as a moderator. Finally, we adopt a comparative lens by investigating protection behavior in four national contexts: Brazil, Germany, the United States, and Vietnam. Results of an online survey (Ntotal = 2,092) show that perceiving surveillance as privacy threat was not consistently associated with active protection behavior. Rather, self-inhibition was a more likely response to surveillance which may have detrimental consequences for both individuals and societies. Across countries, perceived effectiveness of active protection positively relates to both forms of protection while active protection does not prevent self-inhibition. Interestingly, privacy resignation may not always impede protection. In summary, not all aspects of PMT are generalizable when using a culturally diverse sample.

Read article →

Context, script, cue: understanding human-AI intimate relationships

2026-09-01 · DOI 10.1093/JCMC/ZMAG016

Fan Yang; Meiling Du; Ningxin Li; Qing Yan

School of Journalism and Communication, Jinan University , Guangzhou, Guangdong,; School of Journalism and Communication, Xiamen University , Xiamen, Fujian,; School of Journalism and Mass Communications, University of South Carolina , Columbia, SC,

Abstract. Abstract The integration of artificial intelligence (AI) into the intimate sphere of human relationships presents a profound challenge to traditional understanding of intimacy, necessitating a critical examination of this technology's extension into a domain that has always been viewed as deeply human. Through in-depth semi-structured interviews (N = 23), this study examines how human-AI intimate relationships develop in Chinese society at the intersection of traditions and modernization. A three-pronged Context-Script-Cue (CSC) framework emerges, capturing how users navigate emotional investment alongside the artificial nature of AI. By empirically examining how users engage in human-AI intimate relationships, this study offers the new CSC framework for understanding the development of human-AI intimate relationships.

Read article →

Nature Communications

Toward an integrated and globally equitable understanding of political polarization

2026-09-02 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-76110-5

Max Falkenberg; Matteo Cinelli; Alessandro Galeazzi; Christopher A. Bail; Rosa M. Benito; Axel Bruns; Anatoliy Gruzd; David Lazer; Jae Kook Lee; Jennifer McCoy; Kikuko Nagayoshi; David G. Rand; Antonio Scala; Alexandra A. Siegel; Sander van der Linden; Onur Varol; Ingmar Weber; Magdalena Wojcieszak; Fabiana Zollo; Andrea Baronchelli; Walter Quattrociocchi

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

The changing surface of the world's roads

2026-09-01 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-76234-8

Sukanya Randhawa; Guntaj Randhawa; Clemens Langer; Francis Andorful; Benjamin Herfort; Daniel Kwakye; Omer Olchik; Sven Lautenbach; Alexander Zipf

Abstract. Abstract Resilient road infrastructure is a cornerstone of the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), yet spatially consistent information on road surface conditions at the global scale remains limited. We overcome this gap based on a deep learning framework that extracts both road pavedness and road width from Planetscope satellite imagery. Thereby, mapping 95.5% of 9.2 million km of critical arterial roads for 2020 and 2024, nearly half of which was previously unclassified.The resulting dataset and multi-scale analytical framework enable assessments of road infrastructure in the context of development, climate adaptation, and equity.Unlike proxies such as nighttime lights, the data directly captures the physical infrastructure underpinning resilience at higher spatial resolution.This dataset reveals a multi-scale geography of human development, capturing infrastructure investment and accessibility at the planetary scale, enabling a global Humanitarian Passability Matrix for humanitarian logistics, while also providing local insights into road disparities-for example, revealing governance-related patterns in Ghana and highlighting climate-related vulnerabilities in Pakistan.

Read article →

Nature Human Behaviour

Gender and LGBTQ+ representation across college majors and achievement levels using nationally representative US data

2026-09-03 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02510-8

Joseph R. Cimpian; Zachary T. McDermott; Jo R. King; Nathaniel Woznicki; Taek H. Kim

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

The gender gap reconsidered

2026-09-03 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02448-X

Bryce E. Hughes

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Saturation of moral language predicts lower content engagement on social media

2026-09-02 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02560-Y

Cristian Candia; Mohammad Atari; Nour Kteily; Brian Uzzi

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Turning biometrics into a commodity raises privacy and governance risks

2026-09-02 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02587-1

Angel Judel; Jose M. Munoz; Carlos Amunategui Perello; Diego Borbon; Jose Antonio Iglesias; Jose Angel Marinaro; Natalia Monti; Moises Sanchez; Ciro Colombara; Amanda de la Fuente; Aldo Diaz

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

Political Analysis

Correcting for Nonignorable Nonresponse Bias in Ordinal Observational Survey Data

2026-09-04 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10055

Lukas Laffers; Jozef Michal Mintal; Ivan Sutoris

Matej Bel University in Banska Bystrica; National Bank of Slovakia; Norwegian School of Economics

Abstract. Abstract Many political surveys rely on post-stratification, raking or related weighting adjustments to align respondents with the target population. But when respondents differ from nonrespondents on the outcome itself (nonignorable nonresponse), these adjustments can fail, introducing bias even into basic descriptives. We provide a practical method that corrects for nonignorable nonresponse by leveraging response-propensity proxies (e.g., a respondent's rating of the interview or interviewer-coded cooperativeness) observed among respondents to extrapolate toward nonrespondents, while directly integrating observable covariates and retaining the benefits of post-stratification with known population shares. The method generalizes the variable-response-propensity framework of Peress (2010) from binary to ordinal outcomes, which are widely used to measure trust, satisfaction and policy attitudes. The resulting estimator is computed by maximum likelihood and implemented in a compact R routine that handles both ordinal and binary outcomes. Using the 2024 American National Election Study, we show that accounting for nonignorable nonresponse produces substantively meaningful shifts for life satisfaction (estimated latent correlation 0.47 $\rho \approx 0.47$ rho almost equals 0.47), while yielding only modest changes for retrospective economic evaluations (0.14 $\rho \approx 0.14$ rho almost equals 0.14), highlighting when nonignorable nonresponse substantively affects survey estimates.

Read article →

Political Communication

Democratic Accountability in East Asia: A Comparative Experimental Study of Voter Responses to Norm Violations

2026-08-31 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2721665

Woo Chang Kang; Sunkyoung Park; Osbern Huang; Koh Iwabuchi; Tetsuro Kobayashi

Griffith University; Korea University; Waseda University

Abstract. Existing research shows that voters in established democracies often fail to penalize politicians who violate democratic norms, as many are willing to trade democratic principles for partisan interests in polarized environments. Yet such partisan double standards remain underexplored in East Asia, where countries share authoritarian legacies, face ongoing risks of democratic backsliding, and operate under the geopolitical shadow of powerful authoritarian neighbors. Using a large-scale vignette experiment conducted in Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, and the United States (N = 10,194), this study examines whether voters sanction politicians who engage in democratic norm violations. We focus on reactions to three types of undemocratic statements: election denial, protest suppression, and attacks on the judiciary. The results show that voters in East Asian democracies impose stronger penalties than their American counterparts, though the degree and pattern of accountability differ across cases. Election denial consistently generates the strongest sanctions, while Japan and Taiwan show robust reactions across all scenarios. South Korea displays comparatively modest responses to protest suppression, and the United States shows the weakest effects overall. These findings highlight both the resilience and the heterogeneity of democratic accountability in East Asia and underscore the need to understand regional variation when assessing the prospects for democratic stability.

Read article →

From #StayWoke to "Culture Wars": How Social Justice Discourse is Separately and Synergistically Politicized on Twitter and YouTube

2026-08-31 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2717428

Sara Holland Levin; Rui Wang; Junwan Seo; Yi Yin Leong; Emma Bennett; Dongdong Yang; Zhuohui Yang; Matt Chen; Yini Zhang; Jiyoun Suk

University at Buffalo; University of Connecticut

Abstract. This paper explores how the discourse surrounding a racially marginalized community becomes politicized via culture war narratives across platforms. Drawing from identity politics and political polarization research, we discuss how racial justice discourse can be hijacked by partisan opinion leaders and their followers over time and explain how this process plays out through both differentiated and coordinated social media platform use. Situating our discussion in the "woke" discourse as originated within the Black Twitter community, we collect data from 2012 through 2022 on Twitter and YouTube and apply user- and content-level computational analyses. Results show that the term "woke" has been increasingly amplified in culture war conversations on both platforms over time. However, the two platforms exhibited differences: culture war topics dominated on Twitter, while conservative news and commentary channels were most prevalent on YouTube. These two platforms were also interrelated in the politicization process. YouTube was a top domain within external links embedded in tweets, and Twitter was also a top destination within the external links embedded in YouTube video descriptions. Conservatives were especially keen on sharing right-wing content across platforms, from YouTube to Twitter, suggesting the success of cross-platform coordination in amplifying culture wars. Both theoretical and political implications for polarization on social media are discussed.

Read article →

Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

State-sponsored agenda setting: Measuring the impact of narrative laundering

2026-09-04 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2534920123

Patrick L. Warren; Darren L. Linvill; Camille J. Saucier

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Abstract. Foreign information manipulation and interference (FIMI) is an important part of the digital information ecosystem, yet its effects are poorly understood. Most research analyzing FIMI to date is descriptive, exposing efforts to erode trust, promote favorable narratives, and target specific communities. Existing work evaluating the impacts of FIMI contrasts those directly exposed to FIMI messaging (by viewing the original messages) with those who were not, finding little evidence of changes in beliefs or behavior. Rather than persuading individuals directly, we argue FIMI often operates through agenda-setting processes that shape which issues and narratives dominate public discourse. A key component of this process is narrative laundering, whereby misleading content is scrubbed of its origins and circulated into mainstream channels. This study examines the Russian-aligned Storm-1516 campaign, which uses state media, fabricated sites, and paid influencers to elevate false narratives, especially those that implicate Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in corrupt acts. By analyzing the dissemination of these narratives, we assess how Storm-1516 shifts the public agenda, illustrating how foreign influence can exert substantial effects on information environments even when individual-level persuasive effects may be limited.

Read article →

Leveraging generative AI for causal inference with unstructured data

2026-09-03 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2530532123

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Abstract. We introduce GenAI-Powered Inference (GPI), a statistical framework for causal inference using unstructured data, including text and images. GPI leverages open-source pretrained Generative AI (GenAI) models-such as large language models and diffusion models-not only to generate unstructured data at scale but also to extract low-dimensional representations that are guaranteed to capture their underlying structure. Applying machine learning to these representations, GPI enables estimation of causal effects while quantifying estimation uncertainty. Unlike existing approaches to representation learning, GPI does not require fine-tuning of GenAI models, making it computationally efficient and broadly accessible. We illustrate the versatility of the GPI framework through three applications: 1) estimating the effects of Chinese social media censorship while adjusting for textual confounders, 2) isolating the impact of specific image features from that of other correlated features in the same image, and 3) assessing the persuasiveness of political rhetoric. An open-source software package is available for implementing GPI.

Read article →

A three-decade-long analysis shows rising threatened species and responsibility gaps in global supply chains

2026-08-31 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2604868123

Ling Zhang; Quanliang Ye; Ali Kharrazi; Qingxu Huang; Jiansheng Wu; Brian Fath

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Abstract. Rapid globalization and its accordant supply chains accelerates biodiversity loss. Yet timely assessments of biodiversity status and trends remain insufficient, limiting effective conservation actions in response to supply chain dynamics. Here, we provide a three-decade-long analysis of status and trends of three main biodiversity threats and 21,207 threatened species along production, trade, and final consumption between 185 countries. Results show escalating trends and newly identified threat-species-country-activity networks in biodiversity impacts across global supply chains. We identify changes in people's consumption structure and species intensity of economic activities as the main drivers of this escalation. International trade contributes a large and increasing proportion of total threatened species in most countries, especially for imports to the United States, Japan, and exports from Madagascar, Papua New Guinea. In particular, the bilateral trade between the United States and Madagascar causes the largest number of threatened species (191 17) among all bilateral trade flows worldwide. Furthermore, a unique pattern is revealed from our biodiversity assessment, unlike other environmental pressures such as carbon footprints, that species threatened by per-capita final demand in Latin America, and Caribbean (a developing region) is at least 38% higher than those in developed regions and three times the global average. A timely understanding of shared responsibilities of producer- and consumer-nations for biodiversity threats and status offers a scientific basis for fair and accountable biodiversity governance.

Read article →

Aligning private incentives with societal goals in smallholder agriculture

2026-08-31 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2536548123

Gashaw T. Abate; Kaleab Baye; Tanguy Bernard; Jordan Chamberlin; Ruth Hill; Rachid Moussadek; Lamine Senghor

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Abstract. Small-scale farmers in low-income countries are often encouraged to adopt new inputs and practices that generate significant societal benefits, such as improved nutrition, food safety, and environmental sustainability. The limited observability of these attributes, combined with small production scale and misaligned private incentives, leads to adoption levels below the social optimum. Addressing this issue often requires combining instruments identified by different scientific disciplines, spanning across multiple policy sectors, an exercise that is rarely articulated jointly. This paper aims to clarify this, through a simple conceptual framework that explains how farmers decide whether to adopt socially desirable inputs and practices, given the returns and costs they face, their access to financial instruments, and the information and preferences that shape their decisions. It identifies the relevant policy channels, and asks whether the social returns justify the public cost of delivering them. We apply it to three case studies: aflatoxin mitigation, biofortified crop varieties, and conservation agriculture. For each, we identify which parameters bind, which instruments can move them, and how emerging technologies may further contribute. The agenda that follows moves from seeking single-instrument fixes toward identifying the right combination of existing and emerging policy-actionable tools.

Read article →

Cousin marriage and reduced exposure to intimate partner violence and coercive control

2026-08-31 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2600906123

Olympia L. K. Campbell

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Abstract. Cousin marriage, practiced by over 10% of the world's population, restructures kinship networks by overlapping blood and affinal ties. Theory makes competing predictions about how such kin density shapes intrahousehold conflict. "Protection" accounts posit that consanguinity aligns spouses' interests and increases kin oversight, reducing men's incentives and opportunities to use coercion. "Constraint" accounts, by contrast, emphasize that dense kin networks can prioritize family cohesion over women's autonomy, potentially suppressing help-seeking and facilitating control. Here, I adjudicate between these hypotheses using data on ~36 to 46,000 women from Egypt, Jordan, Pakistan, and Turkiye. Using cluster-fixed-effects models that compare women within the same Demographic and Health Survey primary sampling units and survey waves, I find that marriage to a first cousin is associated with a 2.5 percentage-point lower probability of physical intimate partner violence relative to nonconsanguineous unions (11% lower relative risk). Parallel reductions are observed for coercive controlling behaviors and estimates are robust to matching on observed confounders. The protective association for physical violence is stronger for patrilateral than matrilateral cousins, consistent with protection depending on kin with recognized authority over men in patrilineal systems rather than generic relatedness. In Turkiye, the association persists after adjusting for both spouses' parental consanguinity, suggesting that it is not explained solely by family-level characteristics associated with the intergenerational practice of cousin marriage. These findings indicate that, in these settings, consanguinity is associated with lower reported violence and control.

Read article →

Science Advances

Can a public information campaign increase trust in American elections?

2026-09-04 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEC8703

Thad Kousser; Seth J. Hill; Neil Malhotra; Robert M. Stein

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Abstract. Confidence in the conduct and results of American elections has declined and polarized along party lines in recent years. Can a nonpartisan public information campaign featuring election officials enhance trust in elections when delivered to skeptical voters during a contentious political contest? We analyze a preregistered, randomized field experiment conducted

during the 2024 US presidential election in which conservative voters were randomly assigned to a control condition or to receive a multimodal messaging campaign designed by political professionals explaining protections on election integrity. In contrast to the large positive effects of informational messages found in recent survey experiments, we observed primarily null effects with respect to turnout (n = 147,488), general confidence in elections (n = 4740 to 4868), and perceptions of the frequency of fraud (n = 4925). We observed one hypothesized effect: an increase in trust in the vote-by-mail process (n = 6438). This study provides rigorous evidence from a real public information campaign on election integrity, yielding effect sizes in the field that are much smaller than those observed in prior survey settings.

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Digital twins are funhouse mirrors: Five systematic distortions

2026-09-04 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEH8260

Tianyi Peng; Melanie Brucks; George Gui; Daniel J. Merlau; Grace Jiarui Fan; Malek Ben Sliman; Eric J. Johnson; Abdullah Althenayyan; Silvia Bellezza; Dante Donati; Hortense Fong; Elizabeth Friedman; Ariana Guevara; Mohamed Hussein; Kinshuk Jerath; Bruce Kogut; Akshit Kumar; Kristen Lane; Hannah Li; Vicki Morwitz; Oded Netzer; Patryk Perkowski; Olivier Toubia

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Abstract. Scientists and practitioners are aggressively moving to deploy digital twins-large language model (LLM)-based models of individuals-across social science and policy research. We conducted 19 preregistered studies with 164 diverse outcomes (e.g., attitudes toward hiring algorithms and intention to share misinformation) and compared human responses with those of their digital twins (trained on each person's previous answers to more than 500 questions). We establish an empirical benchmark for digital twin performance: Digital twins' answers are only modestly more accurate than those from the (homogeneous) base LLM and correlate weakly with human responses (average correlation coefficient of 0.20). To guide future development, we document five ways in which digital twins distort human behavior: (i) insufficient individuation, (ii) stereotyping, (iii) representation bias, (iv) ideological biases, and (v) hyper-rationality. We make our full dataset and code public as a standardized testbed. Our results caution against premature deployment while laying the groundwork for the transparent, replicable, and iterative science necessary for responsible deployment of digital twins.

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Previous Week Catch-Up

American Journal of Political Science

Partisan bias in a sorted party system: A problem of epistemic inequality

2026-08-26 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70086

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Abstract. Abstract Normative and empirical scholars typically treat partisans' distrust of their political rivals as a product of individual cognitive biases. But even if bias is inevitable, it is parties' coalitionbuilding and messaging strategies that determine who bias is directed toward. This paper argues that the social sorting of party conflict exacerbates the epistemic and democratic harm of partisan distrust by generating distinctive patterns of epistemic inequality. I show that when voters associate parties with particular social groups, members of those groups suffer greater risk of testimonial injustice and related credibility deficits owing to their perceived partisanship. These dynamics are most damaging for members of marginalized groups, as party-group overlap can reinforce the prejudices they already face. Addressing these harms, I argue, requires looking beyond individual partisans to the background features of party systems that shape how elites mobilize group

identities and animus in the struggle for office.

Read article →

Communication Research

Less Effort to Believe and More Effort to Disbelieve: Examining the Interplay between News-Finds-Me and Affective Polarization in Political Fake News Susceptibility in the United States

2026-08-26 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261472023

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Abstract. Drawing upon an online survey of 719 US adult partisans incorporating response latency data, we connected News-Finds-Me (NFM) to the partisan-motivated reasoning literature and theorized it as a consensus-based mode of news exposure that leads to different news-processing pathways, where the vested news-processing effort depends on whether the political falsehood aligns with one's partisan identity and surrounding majority opinion. Individual-level analysis and headline-level modeling jointly illuminated the asymmetric interplay between NFM and affective polarization. In partisan-consistent scenarios, high-NFM users devoted limited processing time, falling short of cognitive effort to enable affect-laden, directional believing of partisan-consistent fake news. However, when challenged by partisan inconsistency, high-NFM users dedicated significantly more processing time, which exacerbated the relationship between affective polarization and refutation of partisan-inconsistent falsehoods. Contrarily, such an effort discrepancy, widely documented in the partisan-motivated reasoning literature, was weakened or reversed for low-NFM individuals. Extending the "Effort-Reinforces-Directional-Reasoning" thesis to fake news vulnerability, our findings underscore the paradoxical interplay between NFM and affective polarization: while NFM and affective polarization deviate people from active news-seeking and accuracy-oriented reasoning, their joint dynamics form a type of group thinking that reduces vulnerability to partisan falsehoods-even those aligned with one's partisan attachments.

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From Exposure to Creation: Cultivating Narrative Ownership to Reduce Stigma

2026-08-24 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261478972

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Abstract. Stories are powerful agents of attitude change, including attitudes toward stigmatized groups. However, existing theories have focused on narrative exposure, with limited attention to narrative creation. Creating a story involves simulating characters and events and expressing them through language, which may engage unique psychological processes. This research investigates how and why creating stories shapes stigma. In three experiments, participants wrote, imagined, or read a positive story about a stigmatized character. Study 1 showed that narrative creation, especially writing, increased psychological ownership, which predicted greater transportation and lower stigma. Study 2 replicated these findings using a different stigmatized group. Study 3 showed that psychological ownership continued to explain the effects of narrative creation above and beyond perceived agency. These findings extend theories of narrative persuasion by considering the effects of story creation on intergroup attitudes and introducing psychological ownership as a novel mechanism linking creation to narrative processing and outcomes.

Read article →

Journal of Communication

Do good chat groups make good neighbors? Continuity and change of norms in neighbor relations under digital co-presence

2026-08-30 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG013

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Abstract. Abstract Based on interviews with urban residents in Germany and Israel, this study examines how residential instant messaging groups (e.g., WhatsApp, Telegram) reshape the norms of "good neighboring": reciprocity, distance, and speaking out. Drawing on Blokland's public familiarity framework and Rosenblum's theorizing of neighborly norms, we ask how digital co-presence transforms the relational conditions of neighboring and how these norms are negotiated within residential chat groups. We show that messenger groups lower the threshold for mutual support but introduce tensions through persistent mutual awareness, which are thenresolved through norm negotiation. Extending the public familiarity framework, we identify a complementary axis of performativity-discretion that manifests through norm negotiation. Residents calibrate between engagement and restraint, enacting "good enough" neighboring within the double-bounded constraints of a building and a chat group. We contribute to research on digitally mediated neighborhood communication by showing how urban dwellers achieve pragmatic coexistence through calibrated visibility.

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Nature

Will Meta's deal make social media safe for kids? Researchers are dubious

2026-08-28 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-02733-9

Kaia Glickman

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Are pro-nuclear politics a threat to public safety?

2026-08-26 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-02509-1

Peter Fairley

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

Nature Communications

Agrivoltaics can reduce political polarization and local opposition to solar energy on land

2026-08-27 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77141-8

Lukas Fesenfeld; Leon Sistek; Simon Montfort; Dionis Anderegg; Jurg Rohrer; Tobias Schmidt

Abstract. Abstract As solar energy deployment on land intensifies, political polarization and local opposition increasingly challenge its social acceptance. We propose that agrivoltaics - a dual land-use technology that combines solar power generation with agricultural production - can help bridge ideological divides and reduce local opposition by minimizing land-use conflicts and offering additional benefits to rural communities. To test this hypothesis, we conducted a pre-registered, field-embedded experiment with a representative sample (2145 Swiss residents) just prior to a national renewable energy referendum, combining a personalized geolocated information treatment on local agrivoltaics potential with

a conjoint experiment varying key technology and project design attributes. Here we show that agrivoltaics garners broad public support across ideological groups and reduces local opposition, especially when projects are well integrated into agricultural landscapes, do not significantly reduce agricultural yields, and are locally owned. These findings underscore the importance of technology and project design in addressing local and right-leaning opposition to land-based solar energy.

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Multi-source agent-based modeling to optimize influenza mitigation strategies in Hong Kong

2026-08-25 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-74857-5

Liping Peng; Yiyang Guo; Nicole N. Y. Tsang; Xiaotong Huang; Hau Chi So; Benjamin J. Cowling; Dennis K. M. Ip; Tim K. Tsang

Abstract. Seasonal influenza control faces challenges from variable vaccine effectiveness and uncertain non-pharmaceutical intervention (NPI) performance. While vaccination remains the primary strategy, its effectiveness varies between vaccine-matched and mismatched seasons. Increased post-COVID-19 NPI acceptance enhances influenza control feasibility, yet optimal combination approaches remain poorly understood. We use an agent-based model to analyze influenza transmission across six seasons in Hong Kong (2009-2013) with varying epidemic characteristics. We integrate surveillance, serological, and school absenteeism data for calibration, enabling accurate estimation of reported and unreported infections. We evaluate age-targeted vaccination, staying home when sick, mask use, and school-based interventions across diverse real-world scenarios. Compared to baseline, child vaccination consistently outperforms other strategies, with targeting those under 12 yielding the greatest population-level attack rate reduction (up to 8.5% relative reduction per 100,000 vaccinated). Among NPIs, 40% mask coverage reduces attack rates by 18%-43%, comparable to 25% of symptomatic individuals staying home. During vaccine-mismatched seasons, combining high-coverage mask use and staying home reduces attack rates by 79%-84%. High-coverage school-based vaccination is more effective than closures, reducing student attack rates by up to 85% versus 33% for 14-day closures. Our multi-source calibration approach provides robust evidence for prioritizing child vaccination and strategic NPI combinations. Modeling six influenza seasons to evaluate mitigation strategies, this study proposes a signal-responsive policy framework. Findings show child vaccination and mask use curb transmission; their combination is vital during vaccine mismatches.

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Nature Human Behaviour

Mentalizing and heuristics as distinct cognitive strategies in human teaching

2026-08-26 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02540-2

Sevan K. Harootonian; Thomas L. Griffiths; Yael Niv; Mark K. Ho

Abstract. Teaching is a foundational social behaviour that can result from mentally effortful reasoning or cognitively frugal heuristics. When do people use these strategies to teach? Here we investigated this using behavioural experiments and computational modelling with adult participants recruited via Prolific. Experiment 1 (N = 100) revealed robust individual differences: some participants taught by reasoning about a learner's knowledge, consistent with an optimal Bayesian pedagogy model, while others relied on simple heuristics that do not require mentalizing. In two preregistered follow-up experiments, we found that people persist in using heuristics even when they are no longer effective (experiment 2, N = 253, P < 0.001, rank-biserial r = 0.287, 95% confidence interval 0.149-0.419) but that this tendency is pre-empted when inference about a learner's knowledge is scaffolded using an auxiliary task (experiment 3, N = 759, P < 0.001, partial $${\eta }_{{\rm{p}}}}^{2}=0.107$$, 95% confidence interval 0.068-0.148). These results demonstrate sophisticated arbitration between planning and heuristics during teaching and elucidate the more general mechanisms involved in adapting mental effort during social interactions. Harootonian et al. find that people switch between effortful, tailored teaching and easier, simple shortcuts, favouring shortcuts even when unhelpful. Prompting participants to reflect on learners' limitations restores effective, personalized instruction.

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Public perceptions of polygenic testing and embryo selection for non-medical traits

2026-08-26 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02562-W

Edmond Awad; Clara Colombatto; Joanna Demaree-Cotton; Brian D. Earp; Jim A. C. Everett; Peng Liu; G. Owen Schaefer; Ilina Singh; Dominic Wilkinson; Julian Savulescu

Abstract. Abstract Some advances in reproductive technologies raise substantial ethical and psychological challenges, for example, the use of preimplantation genetic testing to select embryos based on non-medical traits. While studies have explored public willingness to use preimplantation genetic testing for medical or non-medical attributes, stated willingness may not reflect implantation decisions when such information is available. This large cross-national study examined public views on polygenic embryo testing. In a US sample (N = 1,467), participants were more willing to test for medical conditions (for example, heart disease) than non-medical traits (for example, antisocial behaviour or low intelligence), although over half supported testing for non-medical traits. In a forced-choice implantation task, participants used medical and non-medical information to a similar extent when making decisions. Similar patterns were observed in Chinese participants (N = 623). These findings suggest variability in choices across specific traits and conditions, rather than a uniform distinction between medical conditions and non-medical traits. The Stage 1 protocol for this Registered Report was accepted in principle on 7 October 2025. The protocol, as accepted by the journal, can be found at https://osf.io/vb9c2 .

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Refining the role of behavioural and social sciences in pandemic response post-COVID-19

2026-08-25 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02506-4

Maja Graso; Karl Aquino; Stefan Baral; Nathan Berg; Cory J. Clark; Lucian Gideon Conway; Paul Dolan; Steven Grover; Kyriaki Fousiani; Claudia C. Kitz; Dario Krpan

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Political Communication

Social Media Savvy? The Use and Effectiveness of Political Parties' Issue Strategies Across Platforms in the German Federal Election Campaign 2025

2026-08-26 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2715702

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Abstract. How does the ever-growing relevance of social media shape political campaigning? A vibrant public and academic debate addresses the role of social media in elections and democratic processes. Yet, despite a surge in research, we still know little about the extent to which political parties adjust established issue strategies to the priorities of different social media platforms' audiences and how effective these are in generating user engagement. Drawing on theories of issue competition - issue ownership, riding-the-wave, and issue yield - we analyze parties' social media communication during the 2025 German federal election campaign on Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok. Combining manual quantitative content analysis of party and candidate posts with large-scale survey data from the German Longitudinal Election Study (GLES), we assess both strategic use and effectiveness of issue strategies. Our results show that parties strategically prioritize owned issues and those salient on the general public agenda, often combining both dimensions in issue yield strategies. However, these strategies only partly align with what the specific platform audiences value and reward. User engagement is highest for posts that match platform-specific issue preferences, especially when the issues are salient both to a party's supporters on

that platform and to its wider user base. The findings offer new insights into the dynamics of contemporary digital campaigning and cross-platform party competition.

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Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Perfectibility in science and democracy: Institutions that learn

2026-08-26 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2626408123

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Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Interactive representations of power and status signals in learning social hierarchies

2026-08-25 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2532908123

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Abstract. Social hierarchies, which organize our social relationships, have heterogeneous effects on choice behavior. Two central dimensions of social hierarchies, status, which is earned through recognition of competence, and power, which is the capacity to control the outcomes of others, may contribute to different behavioral profiles. Yet, the neurocomputational processes by which status- and power-related signals are learned based on social feedback, and influence subsequent decision-making, remain unclear. Here, we combine functional neuroimaging with computational modeling to examine how individuals acquire knowledge about others' status and power, and how these learned hierarchy signals shape social influence on advice-taking during a risky choice task. We found that the medial prefrontal cortex covaried with status estimates, whereas the amygdala covaried with power estimates. Moreover, estimates in one dimension influenced choices in the other during learning. This indicates interactions between status and power signals, with retrosplenial cortex activity associated with hierarchy signals beyond immediate choice demands. Finally, status broadly modulated response biases toward both safe and risky advice, whereas power primarily increased bias toward safe advice. These findings characterize how experimentally instantiated status and power signals are learned and influence risky decision-making, indicating partially separable yet interactive representations of these hierarchy signals.

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Science

Correcting the logic behind the 2026 US vehicle emissions standard rollback

2026-08-27 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEF0464

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Abstract. Correction of selective assumptions and inconsistent interpretations of evidence would overturn policy justification

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SciLine helps journalists bring scientific evidence to midterm election news coverage

2026-08-27 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEL7924

Carmen Nobel

Carmen Nobel, previously the director and editor-in-chief of The Journalist's Resource program at Harvard's Shorenstein Center, is helping lead SciLine's election coverage project with SciLine's journalism projects editor, Elena Renken.

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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The worst energy policy in the world

2026-08-27 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEJ2018

Paasha Mahdavi; Michael L. Ross

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Abstract. The Iran war could serve as a turning point in accelerating the global transition away from fossil fuels: Every additional day that oil and gas prices are high and future supplies are uncertain, wind and solar power-cheaper and more scalable than ever before-grow all the more appealing. But nearly half of the world's countries have adopted emergency subsidies that research shows will make this transition slower, more expensive, and less equitable.

Read article →

Science Advances

Identifying heat-related diagnoses in emergency department visits among adults in Chicago: A heat-wide association study

2026-08-28 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AED3977

Hyojung Jang; Peter M. Graffy; Benjamin W. Barrett; Daniel E. Horton; Jennifer L. Chan; Abel N. Kho

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Abstract. Extreme heat is an escalating public health concern. Although prior studies have examined heat-health associations, their reliance on restricted diagnoses and diagnostic categories may miss or misclassify heat-related illness. Here, we conducted a heat-wide association study to evaluate acute-care diagnoses associated with extreme heat in Chicago, Illinois. Using 916,904 acute-care visits-including emergency department and urgent care encounters-among

372,140 adults across four health care systems from 2011 to 2023, we applied a two-stage analytic approach: quasi-Poisson regression to screen diagnosis codes associated with heat, followed by distributed lag nonlinear models in a time-stratified case-crossover design to characterize exposure-response and lag patterns. Stage 1 retained 44 diagnosis codes, and 33 clinically reportable diagnoses were retained after stage 2. We observed elevated cumulative odds over lags 0 to 3 for multiple diagnoses, including fluid-balance and renal disorders, dermatologic and pressure-related conditions, multiple sclerosis, a cannabinoid-related mental and behavioral disorder, varicose veins of the lower extremities, and multiple injuries and external causes. By analyzing the full diagnostic spectrum of acute-care services, this study improves the clinical characterization of heat-associated morbidity in acute-care settings.

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